But what of the Sangh's ideological agenda? Article 370, common civil code, Ram mandir—had that been diluted in the pursuit of power? 'First, let us get a clear majority, then we can talk of implementing our agenda,' said Bhagwat, with a twinkle in his light eyes.

I also asked him why he had sidelined Advani, the seniormost leader in the BJP. Bhagwat then related a story he would later amplify while releasing a book on Advani's blogs in Delhi (which was reproduced in the *Indian Express*). 'In a village, once a housewife spat betel juice into a *havan kund*, only to discover that the spit had turned into a gold nugget. When her husband returned home, she narrated the episode. He told her not to let anyone else know. But word soon spread through the village, and everyone began spitting into havan kunds to find gold. All prospered except the woman and her husband. A year later, when they still had no gold, the unhappy woman told her husband that they should leave the village. He dithered but when she threatened to kill herself, he agreed. They left the village and soon reached a hillock. When they turned around, they saw the village burning and heard people screaming.'

The message, said Bhagwat, was clear—the party and the Parivar needed Advani to stay and guide them so that their 'village' did not burn. Advani was being asked to play a Bhishma-like role by the RSS because the lead actor for the Arjun-like hero had already been found.

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By August 2013, it was apparent that it was only a matter of time before Narendra Modi was formally chosen the BJP's prime ministerial candidate. Modi's town hall meetings continued to attract a huge response. We had begun a series of 'election tracker' polls on CNN-IBN in partnership with Lokniti, the political research team at the CSDS. Our first tracker at the end of July was revealing—Narendra Modi was the preferred prime ministerial choice of 19 per cent of the respondents, Rahul Gandhi of 12 per cent. No other BJP leader was in double digits—L.K. Advani was preferred by just 2 per cent.